‘Okay, so you’re my pupil. What have you learnt till now? Have you been to the helicopter? Have you seen the start-up?’ he said, firing a volley of questions at me.

‘No Sir’ was all I could muster.

‘Okay, let’s meet tomorrow morning,’ he said, and dismissed me. Although I was quite nervous to start my flying training with the CFI, I was happy it was finally going to start. The next day, I was told that the CFI was caught up with some other work and would not be able to fly. It added to my frustration as the other cadets were ahead of me in the syllabus. But when the CFI finally took me to the helicopter late in the afternoon that day, all my doubts flew out of the window. I was amazed to see him explain things with such fluency and detail. In the very first go, he taught me the rate and timing of engaging rotors, something the others had taken days to learn. I realized I was in safe hands and each lesson by Assey Sir, a thorough professional and an experienced instructor, added to my confidence.

Flying a helicopter was very different from flying a fixed wing aircraft. With extremely sensitive controls, a helicopter is inherently unstable to fly. The common mistake all cadets make initially is to give too many inputs to the controls. It takes time to understand that a helicopter is to be flown delicately, and with minimal force. One major difference between a helicopter and a fixed wing aircraft is that a helicopter has the ability to hover above one static point on the ground. As simple as it looked to us cadets, it was the most difficult thing to keep the helicopter steady in the air; it required giving continuous inputs to the controls. When cadets learn this, they tend to get tense on the controls. It happened with almost all of us and would often lead to the helicopter moving unsteadily in the air, also known to us all as an ‘elephant dance’. One could easily tell by the elephant dance that a second-term cadet must be flying the helicopter at the time. Even though the CFI was known to be strict, I had begun to understand that he never raised his voice once he was inside the cockpit. His calm demeanour helped me learn the hovering part faster and better than I would have otherwise. As a result of this, I ended up performing well in the check